

Exercise 2

Setting up a Zoho Creator Account and Exploring the Platform Architecture and Interface

Submitted by

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Architecture Diagram

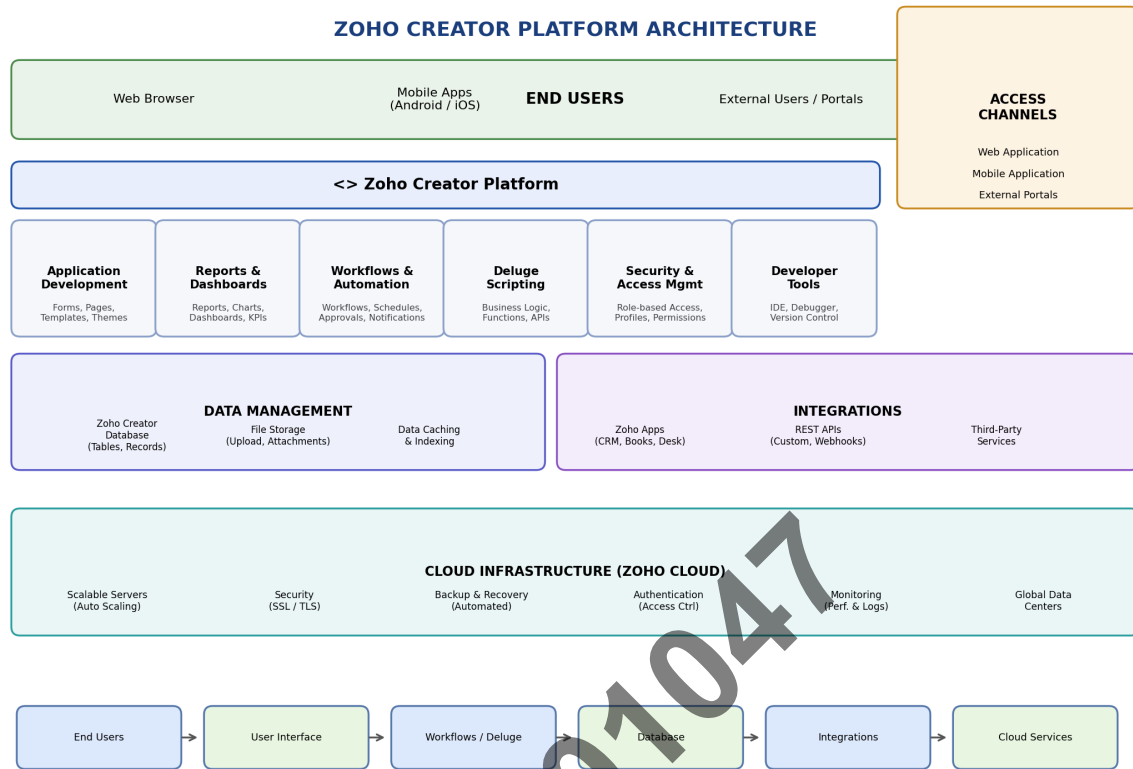


Figure 1: Zoho Creator platform architecture

- **End Users:** Users access the application through a web browser, mobile app, or external portal to perform tasks and manage data.
- **Zoho Creator Platform:** The core platform where applications are developed using forms, pages, reports, dashboards, workflows, and Deluge scripting. It also provides role-based security to control user access.
- **Data Management:** All application data, records, and uploaded files are stored in the Zoho Creator database, ensuring organized and secure data management.
- **Integrations:** Zoho Creator connects with Zoho applications (CRM, Books, Desk, etc.), REST APIs, and third-party services such as email, SMS, and payment gateways to exchange data seamlessly.
- **Cloud Infrastructure:** The platform runs on Zoho Cloud, which provides secure hosting, authentication, automatic backups, scalability, monitoring, and high availability.
- **Data Flow:** End Users → Zoho Creator Platform → Database → Integrations → Cloud Infrastructure

Dashboard

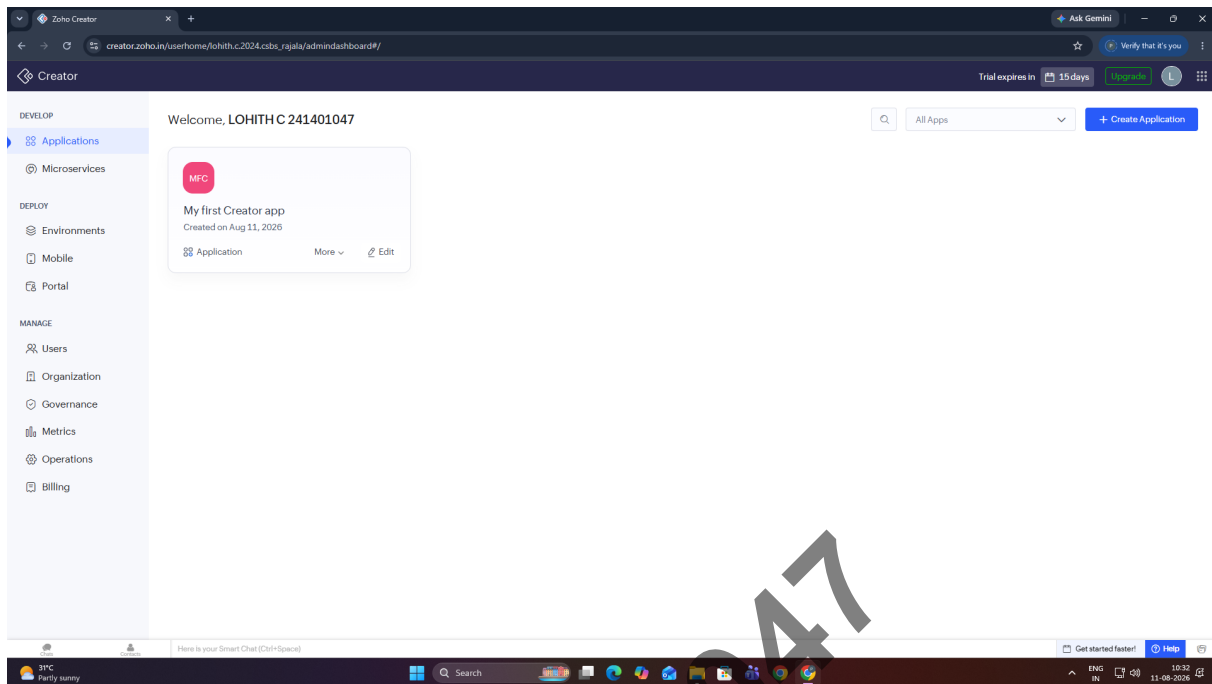


Figure 2: Zoho Creator dashboard - Applications home screen

- The Dashboard is the home page of Zoho Creator, shown under Develop > Applications.
- It is the first screen the admin sees after logging in.
- It provides access to all applications created within the organization in one place.
- Users can create a new application using the Create Application button or open an existing one.
- The dashboard displays the application card with its name, creation date, and quick links to Application and Edit.
- The left navigation panel gives access to Develop (Applications, Microservices), Deploy (Environments, Mobile, Portal), and Manage (Users, Organization, Governance, Metrics, Operations, Billing) sections.
- It acts as the central control panel for developing and managing applications.
- A Smart Chat and Help option are available at the bottom of the screen for quick assistance.

Microservices

The Microservices page, accessed from Develop > Microservices, is used to add modular components that extend an application's capabilities by connecting it with third-party apps and building artificial intelligence features.

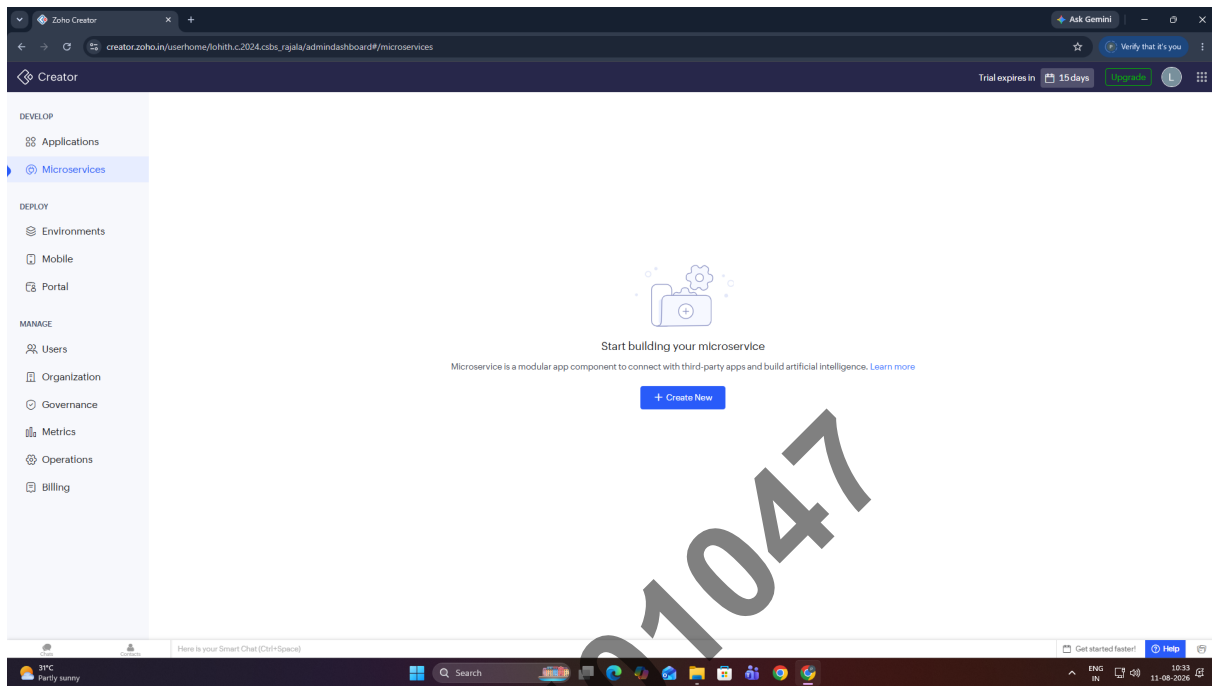


Figure 3: Microservices - Start building your microservice

- Displays a prompt to start building a new microservice when none exists yet.
- A microservice is described as a modular app component used to connect with third-party apps and build artificial intelligence.
- The Create New button opens options to add features such as AI Models, AR Library, Connections, Datasources, and Custom API.
- Helps extend an application with advanced, reusable functionality without rebuilding it from scratch.

Environments (Deployment)

The Environments page, under Deploy > Environments, provides a multi-stage deployment space to test and publish an application without affecting the live production version.

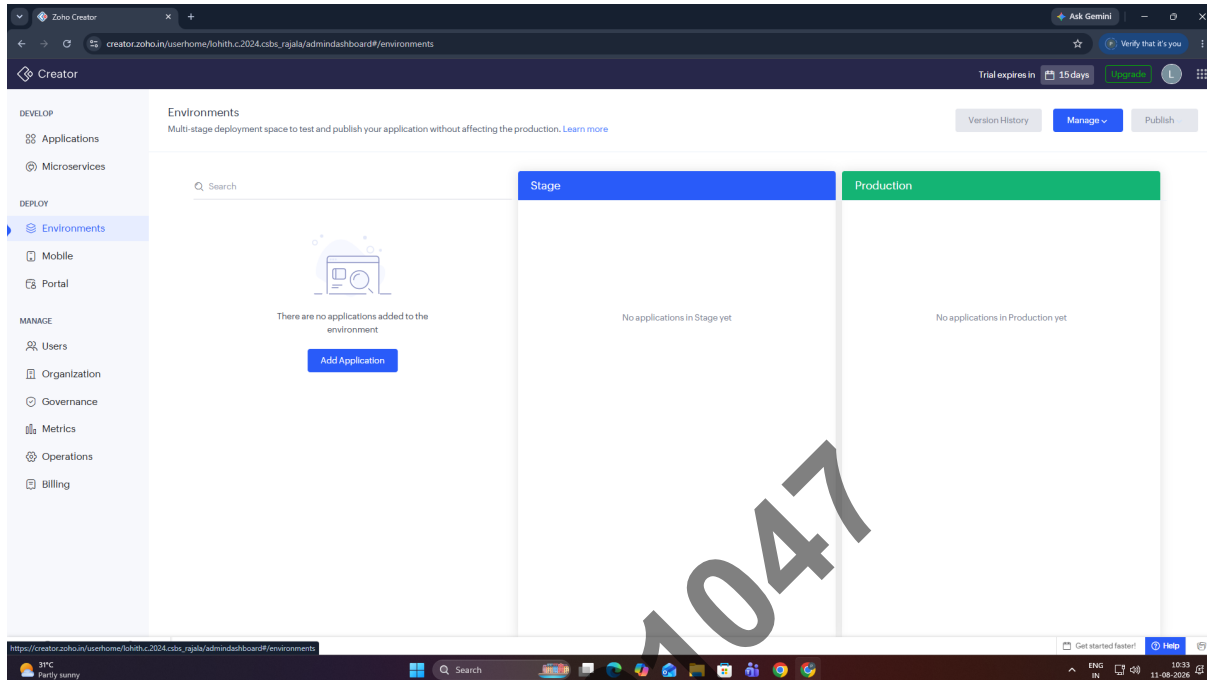


Figure 4: Environments - Stage and Production

- Stage: Used to test the application and verify that features work correctly before publishing.
- Production: Contains the final, live version of the application that end users access.
- The Add Application button adds an application to the environment for staged testing.
- Version History and Manage options let developers track changes and configure the environment.
- The Publish button deploys the tested application from Stage to Production.
- Currently, no applications have been added to either the Stage or Production environment.

Mobile (Deployment)

The Mobile page, under Deploy > Mobile, allows an application to be distributed as a rebranded mobile app for Android and iOS.

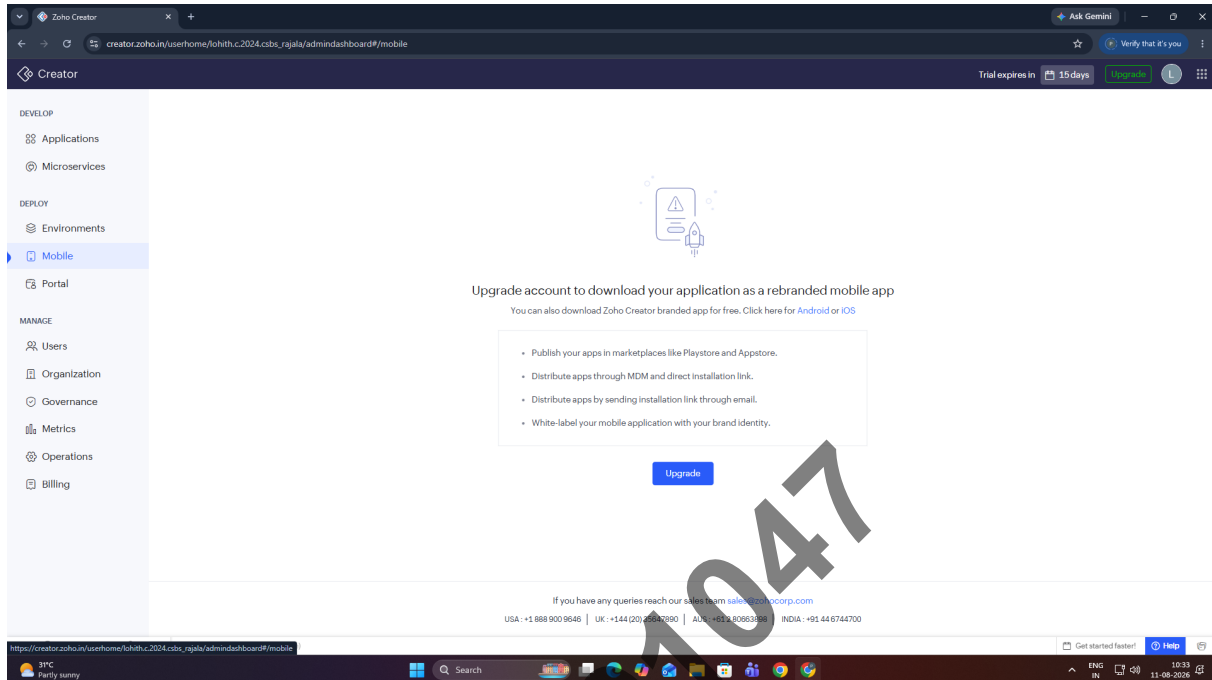


Figure 5: Mobile - Upgrade to download as rebranded app

- On the trial plan, publishing a rebranded (white-labelled) mobile app requires an account upgrade.
- The free, Zoho Creator-branded app can still be downloaded for Android or iOS.
- Upgraded plans allow publishing apps to the Play Store and App Store.
- Apps can also be distributed through MDM, a direct installation link, or by email.
- The mobile app can be white-labelled with the organization's own brand identity once upgraded.

Portal (Deployment)

The Portal page, under Deploy > Portal, is used to create a secure, self-service gateway through which customers and business partners can interact with an application.

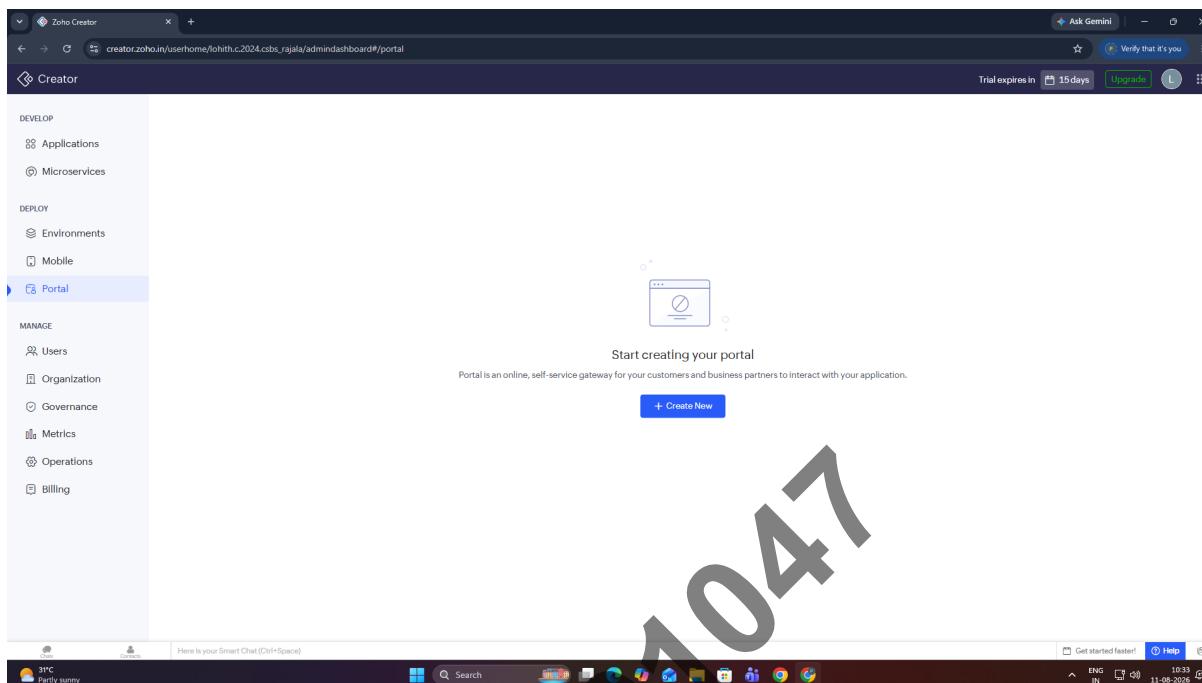


Figure 6: Portal – Start creating your portal

- A portal lets external users such as customers or vendors access the application without needing a full Zoho Creator account.
- The Create New button starts the portal creation process.
- No portal has been created yet for this organization.
- Portals help businesses share specific application functionality with users outside the organization.

Users (Manage)

The Users page, under Manage > Users, lists every individual who has been granted access to the organization's solutions through role-based access control.

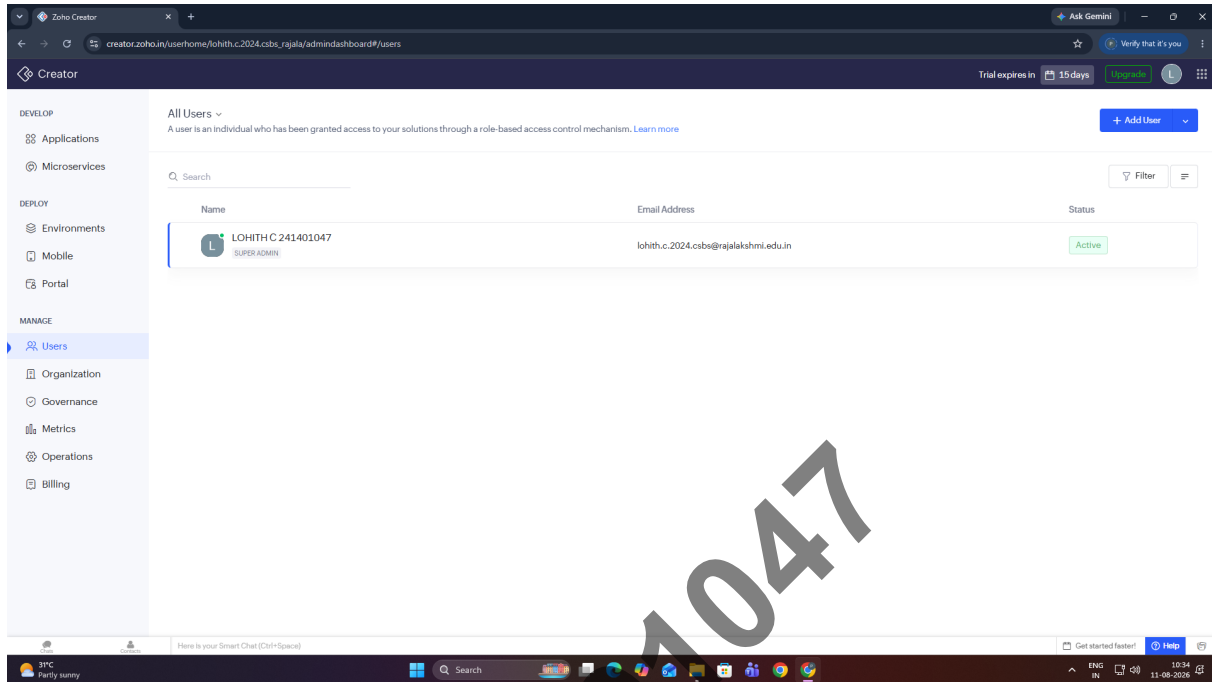


Figure 7: All Users - Super Admin account

- Displays the name, email address, role, and status of every user.
- The account currently has one active user, Lohith C 241401047, assigned the Super Admin role.
- The Add User button allows new users to be invited to the organization.
- Filter and search options make it easy to locate specific users as the list grows.

Organization (Manage)

The Organization page, under Manage > Organization, is used to set up the company's profile, preferences, and branding information.

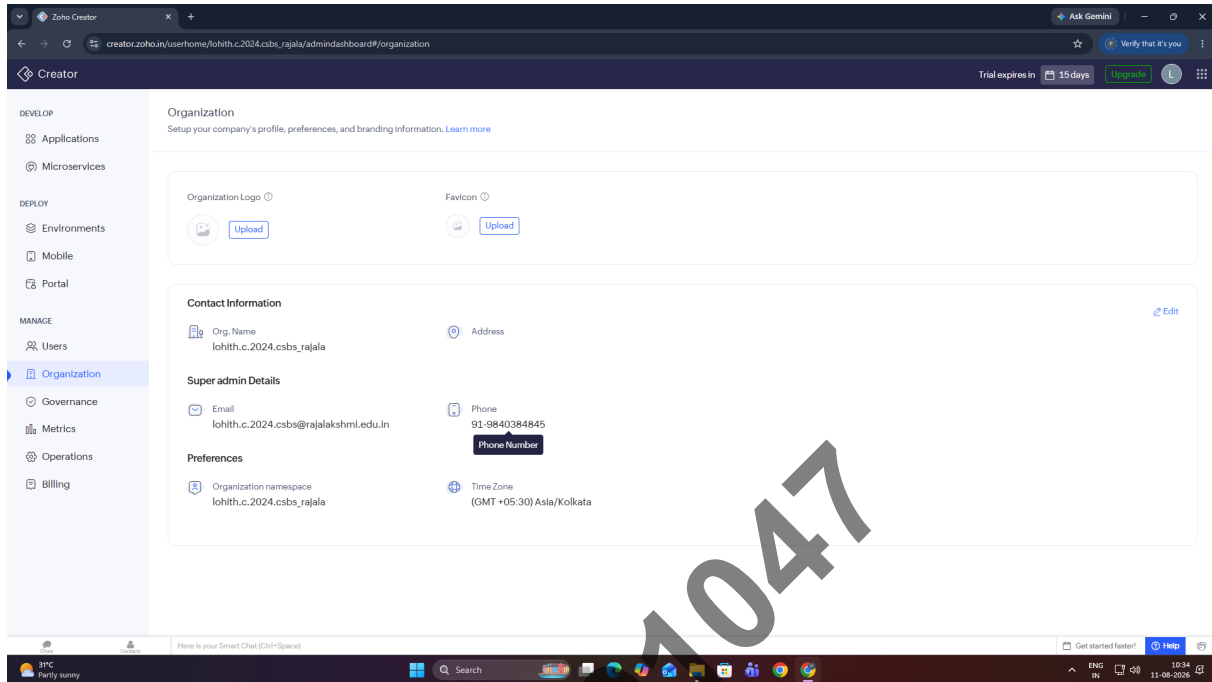


Figure 8: Organization profile and preferences

- Organization Logo and Favicon can be uploaded to brand the account.
- Contact Information shows the organization name, lohith.c.2024.csbs_rajala.
- Super Admin Details display the registered email and phone number of the account owner.
- Preferences show the organization namespace and the configured time zone, (GMT +05:30) Asia/Kolkata.

Governance (Manage)

The Governance page, under Manage > Governance, is used to create a set of governing principles that consolidate the organization's security setup.

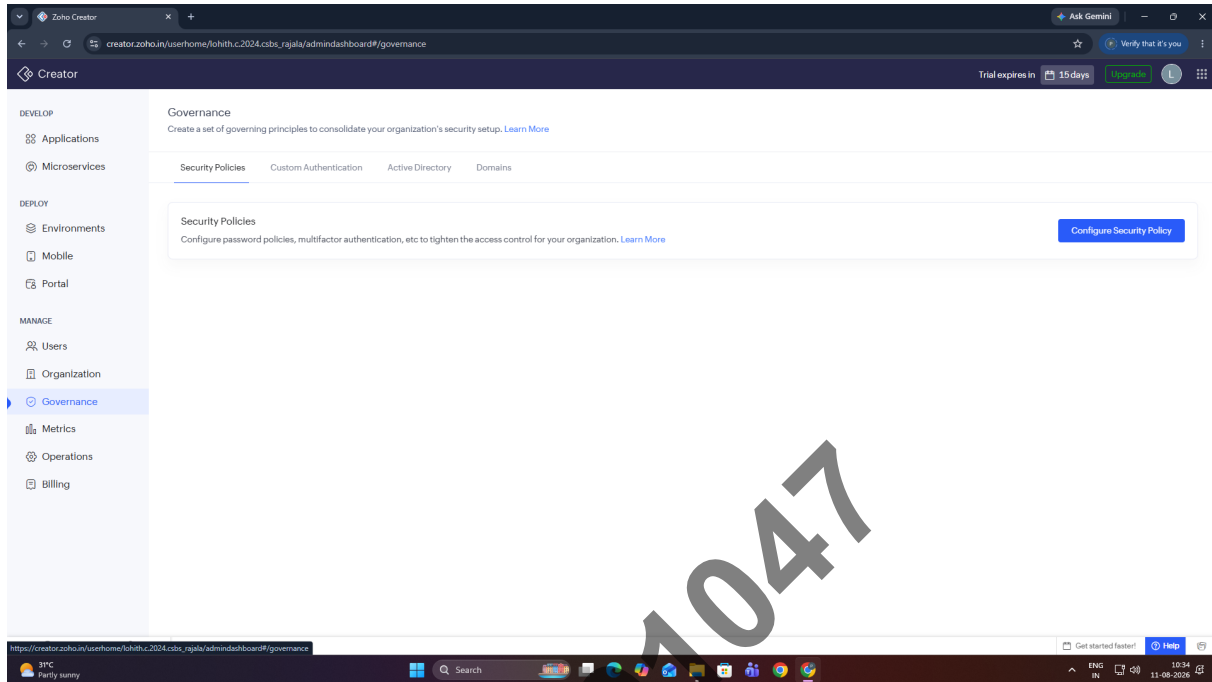


Figure 9: Governance - Security Policies

- **Security Policies:** Configure password policies, multi-factor authentication, and other controls to tighten access for the organization.
- **Custom Authentication:** Set up alternate authentication mechanisms for users.
- **Active Directory:** Integrate the organization's Active Directory for centralized user management.
- **Domains:** Manage the domains associated with the organization's applications.
- The **Configure Security Policy** button opens detailed settings for password rules and multifactor authentication.

Metrics and Operations (Manage)

Metrics

The Metrics page, under Manage > Metrics, is designed to quickly gather insights, trends, and anomalies for all user activity across applications.

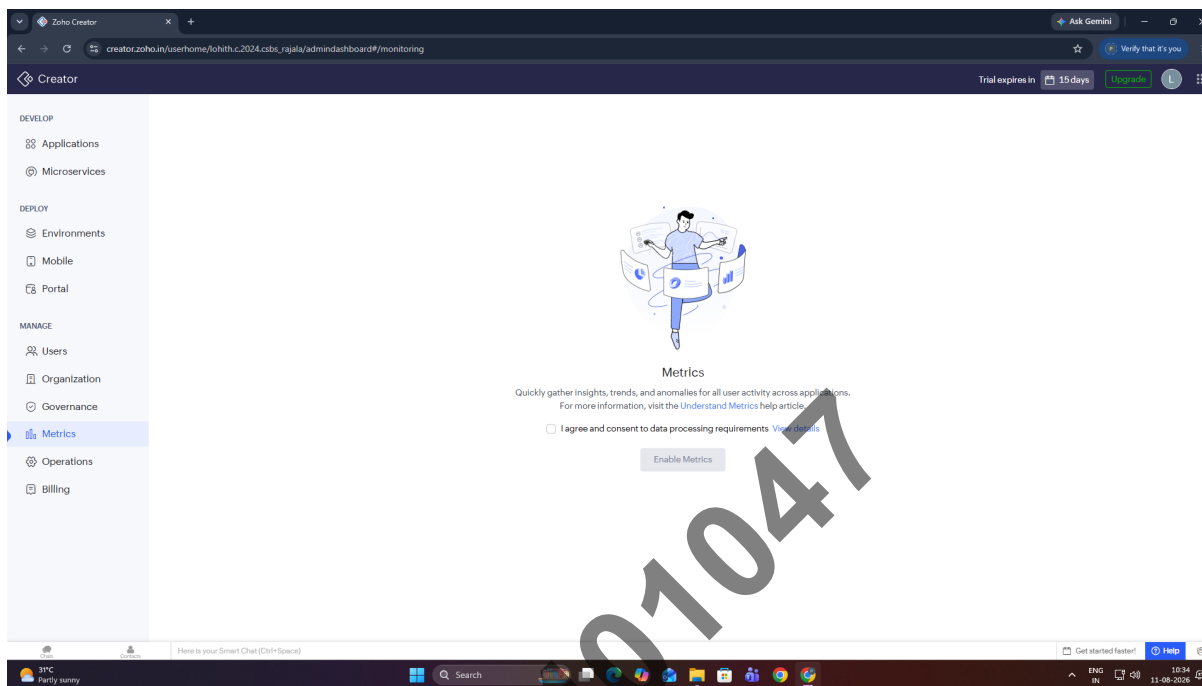


Figure 10: Metrics - Enable Metrics with consent

- Metrics must be explicitly enabled by agreeing to the data processing consent checkbox.
- Once enabled, it monitors application usage, active users, and records created, updated, or deleted.
- Helps identify performance trends and overall application health.

Operations

The Operations page, under Manage > Operations, is a centralized management system used to define and manage the various operations of the account.

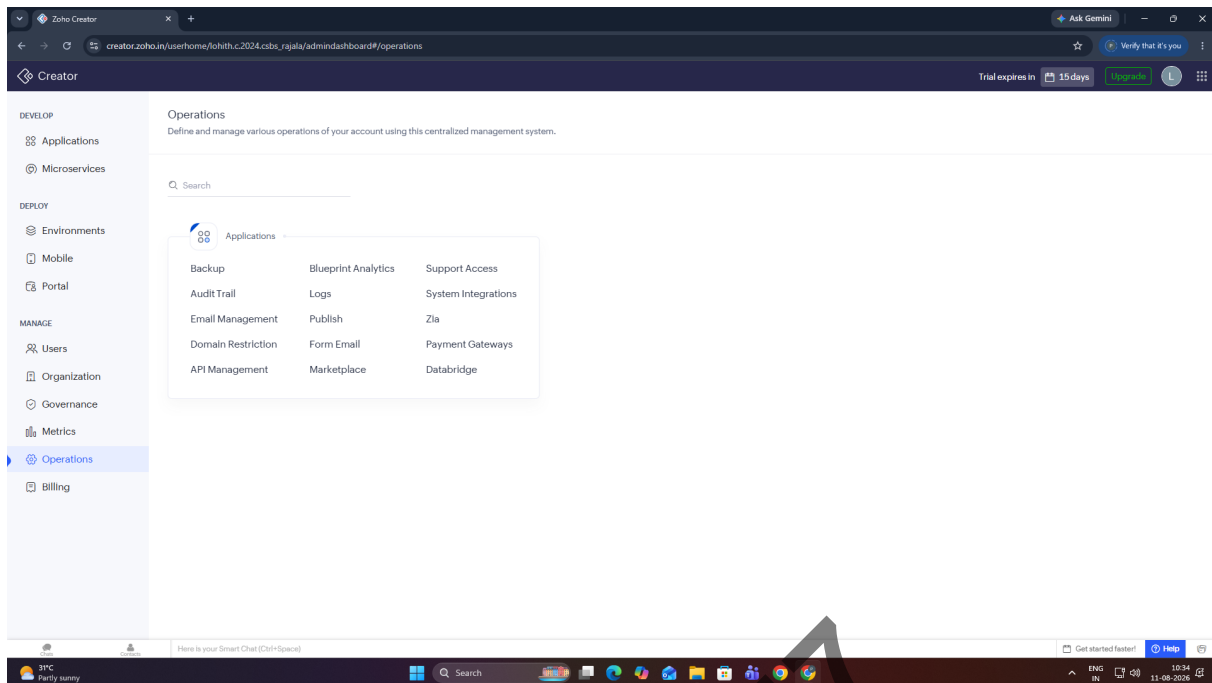


Figure 11: Operations - Applications management tools

- Provides tools such as Backup, Audit Trail, Email Management, Domain Restriction, and API Management.
- Also includes Blueprint Analytics, Logs, Publish, Form Email, and Marketplace options.
- Support Access, System Integrations, Zia, Payment Gateways, and Databridge round out the available operations.
- Helps administrators maintain, troubleshoot, and extend the application from one place.

Billing (Manage)

The Billing page, under Manage > Billing, gives a comprehensive view of the organization's active subscription and lets the admin upgrade the plan or purchase add-ons as needed.

- The account is currently on a trial plan, with the trial ending in 15 days.
- Plan Details show usage of 1 of 10 available user licenses and 1 of unlimited application slots.
- The Upgrade Now button lets the admin move to a paid plan to unlock full platform capabilities.
- A Usage Details tab provides a deeper dashboard for monitoring metrics, insights, and custom alerts.

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Summary

This exercise involved setting up a Zoho Creator trial account and exploring its platform architecture and administrative interface. The Develop section (Applications, Microservices) is used to build and extend applications, while the Deploy section (Environments, Mobile, Portal) manages how those applications are staged, published, and distributed to end users. The Manage section (Users, Organization, Governance, Metrics, Operations, Billing) provides administrative control over access, security, monitoring, and subscription details. Together, these sections form a complete low-code platform for developing, deploying, and managing business applications.

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